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MY FIRST CONVERSATION with Alan Mamedi, the 38-year-old CEO and Co-founder of Stockholm-based caller ID and spam detection app Truecaller happened to be on the micro-blogging site Twitter in January 2020, when I had tweeted, “Life would be better if Truecaller starts telling us WHY the person is calling.” “Noted!” Mamedi had replied then. Merely nine months later, Truecaller was live with its new feature, Call Reason, a new way to tell people why you’re calling.

User feedback like this is essential for Mamedi, who believes in an open and liberal feedback mechanism. Starting out as a Kurdish refugee in northern Sweden, he co-founded Truecaller with his friend Nami Zarringhalam in 2009, which now counts India as its biggest market with nearly 77 per cent of its user base, or 235.5 million active users, located here. Moreover, its data says that a typical Indian phone user receives about 17 spam calls a month on average, as compared to the highest-spammed country Brazil, where users receive around 33 spam calls per month on average. It further says that globally, it has identified and blocked 37.8 billion spam calls in 2021.

Shockingly, 202 million of those calls were made by just one spammer in India, per its 2021 Year in Calling report. And the fact that India has moved from the 9th spot to the 4th in 2021 in a list of countries where users receive the most number of spam calls, makes an app like Truecaller even more relevant. “There’s no secret sauce behind our success here. It’s a combination of our focus on emerging markets as it’s underserved and it was a well-suited time for India, since in the last 10-15 years, it has gone through a massive smartphone and data penetration revolution. As that happens, people need

utility apps that solve core problems,” says Rishit Jhunjhunwala, Chief Product Officer and MD of Truecaller India, who moved back to the country last October from Sweden to focus on the company’s India operations. He adds that in India—traditionally considered as a market that doesn’t like to pay for software—the company’s revenue from subscriptions has grown considerably.

While the Sequoia India-backed Truecaller is synonymous with caller ID and spam detection, it also helps users identify callers by providing a search engine for telephone numbers. As a result, it has been widely criticised for its practice of automatically uploading its users’ phonebooks to its servers without their consent. The company, however, says that its database is mostly user generated and a large number of daily active users (DAU) contribute to it by marking numbers as spam, correcting names, etc. According to Jhunjhunwala, it’s nothing but a big misconception against the company. “It’s a common misconception that Truecaller uploads things to the server and sells data. Another misconception is that we’re a Chinese company, and that’s why the defence forces sent out an advisory against installing Truecaller. We’re actually way ahead of

CALLING FOR A RETHINK

- 1 Nearly 77 per cent (235.5 million) of Truecaller’s active users are from India—its biggest market
- 2 The company says that it’s a misconception that it uploads user’s information to the server and sells customer data
- 3 Rather than being just a background app, the company has aspirations of building an app with more “active engagement”
- 4 Legally, India is in a grey zone due to the absence of a data protection law
- 5 Once the law is put in place, experts say companies engaged in copying, sharing and monetising data will face a tough time in India